What makes our game distinct? A study of hooks

Study, 2026-10-15. Speculative by design. Nothing here is decided; choices go to `docs/decisions.md`.

Where the project stood

- **Stage 2** in progress (shield block T007, spin slash T008 queued; Rat Raider rig parts A004 with the art builder). Stage 1 passed; the Stage 3 rig is done.
- **Decided so far:** belt-scroller, arcade run with River City Ransom-style growth (later branching + boons), block by default, throws, floor weapons and breakables, lives, about 120 px target belt, co-op for up to three, an assembly line of body x colour x weapon kit x gear.
- **Parked:** League-style hero kits, companion/pet, a 360 spin special, the enemy design workspace.
- **The question:** the user ruled out mounts (animals in this world rarely ride) and asked what will make *our* game distinct: co-op, League-style abilities, species x class, or something else.

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1. What a hook is (and the test we'll hold every idea to)

Every genre classic is remembered for one or two ideas that change how **every fight** plays (genre study, section 7). A hook is not a feature list. Our test:

1. **One sentence:** can you pitch it in one line that makes someone want to play?
2. **Every fight:** does it change what you do minute to minute, not just between stages?
3. **Pillars:** every hit lands; fair crowds; you grow by fighting; the art stays doable.
4. **Taste** (the user's): co-op against the game or direct conflict; characters that feel distinct and change during a run; decisions that matter; no fiddly bookkeeping; theme drives mechanics.
5. **Ours:** does it come out of *this* world (animals as peoples, a compressed size scale, heroic and warm) rather than being bolted on?
6. **Cheap to test:** can we prove it fun with art we have, before committing?

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2. Hooks that made other games distinct

Game	The hook	Why it worked
Double Dragon	Weapons from enemies; co-op friendly fire	The floor and your partner become tools (and jokes)
Golden Axe	Mounts; magic pots; thieves	Fantasy chaos; something to chase
River City Ransom	Open town; shops; food raises stats; books teach moves	Growth feels personal and funny
The Simpsons (arcade)	Team-up moves when partners stand together	Co-op as a mechanic, not just two players
Knights of the Round	Level up mid-run	Arcade + growth
D&D Shadow over Mystara	Six classes, spells, inventory, branching paths	A tabletop party in 45 minutes
Guardian Heroes	Three depth lanes; karma; branching story	Choices with consequences
Sengoku series (as recalled)	Transform into different warriors mid-fight	One player, several play styles
Marvel vs Capcom (fighting game)	Call a partner in for an assist on cooldown	A party behind one player
Castle Crashers	Many unlockable knights; animal pets that help	Collecting and companions
Dragon's Crown	Classes, loot, rune spells, AI party members from bones you find	Solo play still feels like a party
Way of the Passive Fist	You only defend (parry and counter)	Inverts the genre's verb
Charlie Murder	Punk band; RPG; tattoos; a social-media phone	Personality and style
Streets of Rage 4	Special moves cost health you win back by attacking	Rewards aggression
Dungeon Fighter Online	Classes with cooldown skill bars and ultimates	Deep build identity
Absolum	Roguelite runs; boons; parry	Replay from recombination
Wildermyth (not a brawler; the user's reference)	Heroes change through story: scars, transformations, relationships	Characters you remember

Two patterns stand out: - **Party fantasy:** Mystara, Dragon's Crown and Marvel vs Capcom make one player feel like a team. - **One inverted or doubled verb:** parry-only, health-as-fuel, transform mid-fight.

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3. The candidates, honestly assessed

A. Co-op by itself

Every modern brawler has 2–4 player co-op. On its own it **isn't distinct**. It becomes distinct when the team has mechanics only a team can do (see C and D). *Verdict: necessary, not a hook.*

B. League-style kits (passive + three cooldown abilities + an ultimate)

Strong hero identity and clear co-op roles (tank, damage, support). Dungeon Fighter did it, but few Western brawlers have. Risks: buttons (keyboard and phone), and balancing kits is real work. It fits the user's love of League. *Verdict:*

a strong ingredient; on its own, "Dungeon Fighter with animals".

C. Species x class: build your hero

- **Species** sets the body and one innate trait. For example: a mouse is small (slips under high swings, light, fast); a badger is heavy (can't be knocked down mid-swing, slow); a squirrel jumps high and hangs from things; a hare dashes; a hedgehog's spines hurt whoever grabs it.
- **Class** is a **weapon kit**: fighter, archer, mage, rogue.
- **Fits our tech perfectly:** it's exactly the body x weapon kit assembly line. One rig per species, kits shared across species.
- **Fits the world:** species are peoples with their own ways, and the compressed size scale makes size meaningful.
- **Risk:** combinations multiply balancing. Keep species traits to one each and kits small, and let bots check.

Verdict: the most "ours" option, and cheap to scale.

D. Size as a team mechanic

In a compressed-scale world, a badger is twice a mouse's height. That can matter in fights: - **Team throws:** a big hero hurls a small ally across the belt as a living cannonball (Castle Crashers wanted throwable partners and cut it). - **Small heroes** slip between legs to hit a big enemy's back, or get under high swings. - **Big heroes** can't be thrown; small ones can be grabbed by big enemies, and a partner has to free them. - Enemies of different sizes ask different questions (a beetle you can't throw, rats you can).

Verdict: distinctive and thematic; works best combined with C.

E. Your party, even solo (swap and assist)

You bring a **party of three**. Solo, you control one and **tag-swap** to another at any time (switching kit and size mid-fight), or **call one in** for a quick assist on a cooldown (Marvel vs Capcom). In co-op, each player takes one member. That answers "what does co-op add": in solo you're juggling a team; in co-op your friends *are* the team. - **Fits:** co-op against the game (taste), the planned three-player co-op, companion/pet (an AI party member is the companion), and C (a party mixes species and classes). Assists are a natural home for League-style ultimates. - **Cost:** AI for benched partners only during assists (simple); one rig per party member (the assembly line).

Verdict: a strong spine that turns A, B, C and D into one idea.

F. Mercy: enemies are people

In this world rats, stoats and the rest are peoples, not monsters. When an enemy is beaten, a choice: knock them out (normal) or **spare** them. Spared enemies flee. Later they might return the favour, sell to you, or warn others, so fewer fight. Or some could join the party. - **Distinct:** almost no brawler does this. It fits a warm, heroic tone and gives meaning to fights. - **Risks:** it can slow the arcade flow, and a "kill vs spare" choice can turn into bookkeeping. Keep it to one button on a downed enemy, with consequences between stages, not mid-fight.

Verdict: a distinctive flavour layer; strong for story, optional for the core loop.

G. Feasts instead of shops

River City Ransom's food that raises stats, recast as **camp feasts between stages**. Ingredients come from crates and enemies; cooking a dish gives the whole party a buff for the next stage. Food is central to the cosy-heroic animal fantasy tradition, and the art bible already has pie and cheese. *Verdict: a charming home for the RPG layer (Stage 6). Flavour, not the core hook.*

H. Double-edged trinkets

Every power-up has a side effect, for example strong attacks but a growing temper that makes you hard to stop. It's the roguelite boon layer (direction C in the genre study) with a twist that makes choices interesting. *Verdict: a good home for the later roguelite step.*

I. Heroes who change (the Wildermyth idea)

Over a run, heroes pick up scars, gear and titles that **show on the rig** (gear layers and part swaps), plus a small trait. It's cheap with our parts system, and memorable. *Verdict: a lovely long-term layer; not first.*

Ruled out or deprioritised

- **Mounts:** the user's call. A riding animal doesn't fit a world where animals are the people. (A "battle cart" or a war-boar pulled by allies could be a one-off set piece, but no.)
- **A parry-only game** (Way of the Passive Fist style): too narrow for a party brawler, but parry as a skill layer on block stays possible.

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4. Three coherent pitches

Pitch 1: "The Fellowship" (recommended to test first). *"Build a party of three animal heroes, each a different species and class, and swap or call them in mid-fight. Play solo as a whole party, or with friends who each take a hero."* Core: E (party swap/assist) + C (species x class) + D (size team moves). Later: B (kits for each class), G (feasts), I (heroes change).

Pitch 2: "Kit Brawler". *"A League-style hero brawler: each animal hero has a passive, three abilities and an ultimate; team up with friends in roles."* Core: B + co-op roles. Fewer, deeper heroes. Distinct mainly through hero design.

Pitch 3: "The Merciful Blade". *"A warm-hearted brawler where your enemies are people: spare them and the world changes."* Core: F + G + I. Story and tone carry it; combat stays classic.

These combine: Pitch 1 can carry simple kits (one cooldown ability and an ultimate per class, borrowed from Pitch 2) and a spare-or-defeat choice (from Pitch 3) without losing focus.

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5. How we'd prove it cheaply (before committing)

Using art we already have (the art bible's Badger Guardian and Squirrel Ranger standees): 1. **Assist test:** press a key and the Badger Guardian standee leaps in, does one heavy slam, and leaps out (cooldown about 8 s). Does calling a

friend feel great? 2. **Swap test:** swap between Mouse Fighter and a Badger standee mid-fight (different speed, damage, weight). Does switching style mid-crowd feel good or confusing? 3. **Size test:** the badger throws the mouse across the belt as a projectile. Funny and useful, or gimmick?

Each is a small code task and needs no new art. One playtest answers whether Pitch 1 is the spine.

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6. Questions for the user

1. Which pitch excites you most: Fellowship, Kit Brawler, Merciful Blade, or a mix?
2. Party size in solo: three (matches co-op) or two?
3. Do you want the hook tests (section 5) before or after finishing Stage 2's crowd tools (block, throws, weapons)?